

The idea was to make these licences more permanent and reliable,” he explains.

The driving licences and vehicle registration certificates issued on smart cards today stem from the work done in Prof. Rajat Moona’s lab. “We developed the standards and worked closely with NIC,” he states proudly, recognising that his vision of contributing to his country had materialised. After the project’s success, Prof. Moona became involved in several other initiatives.

For Prof. Moona, work is worship. “Whatever work you choose to do, do it with complete devotion, without worrying about the rewards or recognition it could bring. Work for your own satisfaction. Initially while I was working at HCL, I was not satisfied, and it would have been unfair to continue. The greatest reward is your own satisfaction and learning,” he adds.

In 2009, Prof. Moona was invited to join the Technical Experts Committee for electronic voting machines (EVMs). “Initially, the committee had five members, but after the unfortunate passing of the chairman and the health complications of another member, the core team was reduced to three. We became very active in the development of the M3 version of the EVM. I took full responsibility for the software, while two other faculty members focused on instrumentation and electronics, together designing the console, working closely with engineers from BEL and ECIL to bring the M3 machines to life,” he elucidates.

In June 2011, Prof. Moona moved to Pune with his wife and son to join CDAC as the Director General, supervising and defining the research directions for CDAC and working with various research groups with over 3000 employees. This is where he worked on building the technical design—software and RF—for electronic toll collection. “This technology was developed in our laboratory!” he states proudly.

While in Pune, he continued to support the research for electoral voting machines. Today, Prof. Moona is an active member of the technical committee of the Election Commission of India for EVMs and has played a huge role in revolutionising the electoral process for the largest democracy in the world. His contributions did not stop at M3 EVMs and VVPAT but have expanded to designing the national voter service portal and national electoral search for the voters. He received the National Award of the Election Commission of India for the best electoral practices, in 2016.



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